

In 1466, Verrocchio accepted 14-year-old Leonardo as an apprentice on a seven-year contract. Apprentices started out doing everything from sweeping the floor to mixing paints and preparing canvases.

They were allowed to practice painting on tablets made from a hard wood called boxwood. The paint could be scraped off so the tablet could be reused. A story passed down by Giorgio Vasari (an Italian painter, architect, and writer) told how Ser Piero was once asked if he could have a piece of wood painted to turn it into an attractive shield. Piero agreed and brought the wood to Leonardo to see what he might do with it.

Recognizing that the shield was a weapon for battle, Leonardo decided to paint a fearsome image that would frighten anyone with the misfortune to see it.

